

Deepa Palaniappan

Disability Inclusion & Accessibility | Policy, Research and Capacity Building | Government and International Organisations

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PROFILE

Disability inclusion, accessibility and policy professional with over a decade of experience across government, United Nations and World Bank systems, academia and grassroots practice. Assistant Professor at Azim Premji University; consultant to the WHO Disability Unit, Geneva (two assignments) and the World Bank; and State Disability Consultant to the Governments of Bihar, Odisha and Tamil Nadu. Work spans policy drafting and analysis, research and documentation, curriculum and training-material development, and capacity building of government officers and institutional cadres. IAAP-certified accessibility professional (CPACC) with applied expertise in assistive technology, document accessibility and built-environment accessibility.

EDUCATION

- **Mid-career Master's in Development Studies**, Graduate Institute Geneva (IHEID), full scholarship, 2019 to 2021. Thesis: case study on the National Rural Livelihoods Mission and disability inclusion.
- **MA and MPhil, Political Science, Jawaharlal Nehru University**. MPhil dissertation: "Approaches to Disability: Norms, Discourse and Policy".
- **UGC NET qualified, Political Science**.
- **PG Diploma in Special Education (Neurological Disorders and Multiple Disabilities)**, University of Delhi.

AREAS OF EXPERTISE

- Disability-inclusive development and mainstreaming
- Accessibility: digital, document and built environment
- Training, capacity building and curriculum development
- Reasonable accommodation and legal frameworks
- Disability policy drafting, analysis and review
- Assistive technology solutions and advisory
- Research, documentation and report writing
- Multi-stakeholder and inter-governmental coordination

PROFESSIONAL EXPERIENCE

Assistant Professor, then Consultant — Office of Disability Inclusion, Azim Premji University

Assistant Professor Dec 2022 to Jul 2025; Consultant Jul 2025 to present

- Taught and developed course content; led reasonable-accommodation, disability-inclusion and accessibility interventions across the University.
- Designed and delivered training and faculty-development sessions; liaised with faculty, departments and external experts.

Consultant — World Health Organization HQ, Disability Unit, Geneva (two assignments)

Oct 2021 to Sep 2022; Aug 2023 to Dec 2023

- Contributed to the WHO Global Report on Health Equity for Persons with Disabilities (2022): scoping review on health emergencies and disability, and analysis of disability inclusion in national health and disability policies.
- Reviewed WHO documents for disability-inclusion components; mapped organisations of persons with disabilities across countries; coordinated stakeholder consultations including sign-language interpretation.

Consultant — World Bank / Government of Tamil Nadu (TN RIGHTS Project)

Project consultancy 2021 to 2022; State Disability Policy drafting committee 2026 to present

- Initiated and facilitated a CBR core group and multi-stakeholder consultations; drafted a CBR policy and supported the State implementation plan and accessibility inputs.
- Currently a member of the two-person committee drafting the Tamil Nadu State Disability Policy.

Consultant — UN OHCHR (mandate of the UN Special Rapporteur)

May to Jun 2022

- Compiled and analysed disability and leprosy-inclusion policies globally; submitted a research report with a Global South focus.

State Disability Consultant — Govt of Bihar (JEEVIKA / State Rural Livelihoods Mission), Govt of Odisha (OLM), Sightsavers India

2016 to 2021

- Mainstreamed disability inclusion across a state poverty-alleviation programme; built convergence channels with state and central government departments.
- Developed the State Disability Inclusion guideline (in implementation since 2020); designed and delivered training for district, block and state officials.

Research roles — SDRS New Delhi (Research Fellow); International Disability Alliance, Geneva (Research Intern); VSO India

2013 to 2017

- Field and policy research; co-authored a study on inclusive curriculum in Government Industrial Training Institutes for a UNICEF-sponsored publication.

CURRICULUM, TRAINING MATERIALS AND DOCUMENTATION

- Developed the State Disability Inclusion Guideline for the Bihar State Rural Livelihoods Mission, in implementation since 2020.
- Developed training modules, session plans and orientation curricula for Odisha Livelihoods Mission and Bihar SRLM staff.
- Co-authored a situational study on inclusive curriculum in Government Industrial Training Institutes (UNICEF-sponsored publication).
- Contributed to the WHO Global Report on Health Equity for Persons with Disabilities (2022).
- Drafted a CBR policy and implementation inputs for the World Bank TN RIGHTS project; member of the committee drafting the Tamil Nadu State Disability Policy (2026).
- Developed and maintains a documentation and capacity-building web portal for practitioners and advocates (disability-rights-repository.org).

SELECTED TRAINING AND CAPACITY-BUILDING DELIVERY

- District-level training for Rural Development officials across 13+ Bihar districts (Jeevika / SRLM).
- State Resource Person: video-conference training for 26 district and block officials, Government of Bihar (Department of Social Welfare).
- Key Resource Person: orientation for Block and State officials, Odisha Livelihoods Mission, SIRD Bhubaneswar.
- Resource Person: State-level DPO training-cum-workshop, Jharkhand State Livelihoods Promotion Society and Sightsavers.
- Resource Person: consultation workshop on inclusive TVET curriculum in ITIs, Regional Vocational Training Institute, Bangalore (VSO India).
- Faculty Development Workshop, Mangalore University (2025); seven-day workshop on accessibility, NIT Rourkela (2025); pre-conference workshop, BITS Hyderabad (2025).
- Resource Person: IGNOU workshop for Deputy and Assistant Registrars and Section Officers.
- Financial Inclusion training for bank managers on RBI inclusive-banking guidelines, Nalanda district.
- Resource Person and keynote speaker, International Symposium, NIT Rourkela (2025).

PUBLICATIONS

- “Enabling Policies”, Yojana Development Journal, Government of India (Publications Division), December 2020.
- Friedner, M., Ghosh, N., and Palaniappan, D., “‘Cross-Disability’ in India? On the Limits of Disability as a Category”, South Asia Multidisciplinary Academic Journal.
- Palaniappan, D., and Rodrigues, V., “Disability within the Rawlsian Framework of Justice”, in A. Ghai (Ed.), Disability in South Asia: Knowledge and Experience, Sage Publications, 2018.
- Palaniappan, D., and Guru, P., “Skill Training for Adolescents with Disabilities: Government Industrial Training Institutes in Jharkhand”, in Sonpal and Vaishnav (Eds.), Empowering Children with Disabilities (UNICEF-sponsored).
- “Inner Marginalities and Sub-Group Politicization within the Disability Movement”, Cafe Dissensus, August 2016.

- Book Review, International Journal of Disability Studies, Vol. 9, No. 1-2, 2015, SDRS Publications.
- “ICT4D and Accessibility: ICT-based Development Projects and Tools for Rural Communities in India”, Conference Proceedings, National Symposium, ICAR-CIAE Bhopal, 2016.

CONFERENCE ENGAGEMENT

- Invited panellist, “Disability Justice: Looking Beyond Ableist Frames”, IDSK Kolkata, 2024.
- Invited speaker, National Conference on State, Society and Disability Law, University of Hyderabad.
- Invited panellist, University of Chicago (Delhi Centre) Round Table, New Delhi.
- Session Chair, National Conference on Access to Higher Education, Jawaharlal Nehru University, 2015.
- Panellist and panel moderator, World Health Innovation Forum, AMTZ Visakhapatnam, 2024 and 2025.

A detailed list of conference papers presented, panels chaired and workshops conducted is available on request.

FELLOWSHIPS, CERTIFICATIONS AND COMMITTEES

- SYLFF Fellow (Ryoichi Sasakawa Young Leaders Fellowship Fund), JNU, 2010 to 2013 (doctoral research).
- Distinguished Fellow, Kalam Institute of Health Technology (WHO Collaborating Centre), 2023 to 2025.
- Sarai-CSDS Student Stipend Award, 2005 to 2006.
- Certified Professional in Accessibility Core Competencies (CPACC), IAAP.
- Certified Disability Rights and Accessibility Consultant, US Institute of Diplomacy and Human Rights, Washington DC.
- Member, Disability Informatics Sub-Committee, Bureau of Indian Standards, Government of India.
- Ex-General Council Member, NIEPID (nominated by the Ministry of Social Justice and Empowerment).
- Technical Committee Member, Purple Building Certification Scheme (accessibility rating for public buildings).
- Certificate Programme in Assistive Technology (6 months), NISH Trivandrum; DEI programme (FICCI); CII-IBDN Disability Inclusive Leaders; WHO QualityRights training.